

CASHEW QUALITY ANALYSTS' ASSOCIATION, GHANA (C.Q.A.A.G)

PART 1: CONSTITUTION (2025)

PREAMBLE

WE, the Cashew Quality Analysts' Association, Ghana,

Recognizing that the cashew industry is a vital pillar of our nation's economy, providing livelihoods for hundreds of thousands of farmers, particularly in rural communities, and contributing significantly to Ghana's export earnings and agricultural diversification;

Aware of the challenges facing the sector, including quality inconsistencies, climate vulnerabilities, limited local processing due to lower production of high quality raw materials, and the need for enhanced professional standards to meet global demands;

Convinced that rigorous, ethical, and unified quality control is essential to elevating Ghanaian cashews to world-class status, ensuring fair returns to all the stakeholders, protecting consumer health, and promoting sustainable practices;

Inspired by the spirit of unity, integrity, and excellence embodied in our national ethos, and committed to fostering collaboration among stakeholders for the common good;

Do hereby establish this Association of Cashew Quality Controllers of Ghana as a non-profit body to promote professional development, ethical practices, sustainability, and advocacy in cashew quality control for the advancement of our profession, the empowerment of our communities, and the glory of Ghana.

Article One (01): Name, Geographical Structure, Visions, Missions, Motto, Core-Values, Interpretation and Definitions, Objectives

1.1 Name: The Association shall be known as the "Cashew Quality Analysts' Association, Ghana (C.Q.A.A.G)", a non-profit organization registered under the laws of the Republic of Ghana.

1.2 Non-Profit Status: The association operates exclusively for charitable, educational, and scientific purposes. No part of its net earnings shall benefit any private individual. Upon dissolution, assets shall be distributed to similar non-profit organizations.

1.3 Geographic Structure:

- **Headquarters:** The Headquarters/the National Office shall relocated to Techiman-Bole Chapter.
- **Regional Chapters/Branches:** The Association shall organize its Regional Chapters primarily based on key Cashew Production zones and logistical hubs as follows:
 - **Sampa Chapter:** (From Jama North District, Banda District, Tain District, Berekum East and West District, Sunyani)
 - **Drobo-Dormaa Chapter:** (Jama South District, Dormaa Districts, Entire Western North, Ahafo Region)
 - **Techiman-Bole Chapter:** (Wenchi, Bono East Region, Savanna Region, Northern Regions)
 - **Tema-Port Chapter:** (Volta Region to Eastern Region, Ashanti to Western

region, Greater Accra Region)

- **Status of the Chapters:** The Chapters shall be semi-autonomous units operating under the Headquarters guidelines.

1.4 Visions: The Association Vision and Sub-Visions shall be:

"A Ghana where every cashew nut meets global excellence standards through skilled, ethical, and innovative quality practices and analysis, driving sustainable prosperity for farmers, traders, processors, and the nation."

- **Sub-Visions:**
 - **Vision 1:** Shall establish Ghana as a Global Benchmark for Cashew Quality
 - **Vision 2:** Shall foster Sustainable and Resilient Cashew Ecosystems
 - **Vision 3:** Shall help Advance Professional Excellence Among Cashew Controllers
 - **Vision 4:** Shall promote Value Addition and Economic Empowerment
 - **Vision 5:** Shall build Collaborative Networks for Advocacy and Innovation

1.5 Missions: The Association Missions shall be:

- **Mission 1:** Establish, Uphold and Enforce Rigorous Quality Standards in collaboration with the Regulator (TCDA), the cashew council (CCG) and the Security Agencies.
- **Mission 2:** Build Professional Capacity through Education, Examinations and shall contribute to License all Cashew Quality Controllers practicing in Ghana.
- **Mission 3:** Advocate for Sustainable and Equitable Practices by all the Cashew

Stakeholders.

- **Mission 4:** Facilitate Collaborations and Policy Advocacy that shall increase quality and quantity product.
- **Mission 5:** Shall promote Research especially on quality data collection and Innovation.

1.6 Motto: The Association Motto shall be: "Guardians of Ghana's Cashew Quality"

1.7 Core Values: The Association Core-Values shall be:

- **Integrity:** Unbiased and accurate analysis. Shall uphold unwavering honesty, transparency, and ethical conduct in all cashew control activities and shall ensure accurate inspections free from bias or corruption.
- **Excellence:** Pursuit of world-class standards. Shall strive for the highest standards of professionalism and precision in cashew.
- **Sustainability:** Shall promote environmentally responsible and resilient practices that shall protect the ecosystems then the long-term viability of cashew farming.
- **Professionalism:** Shall foster competence, respect, and ongoing development among cashew controllers through education and ethical standards.
- **Collaboration:** Shall value partnerships and unity among stakeholders to advance shared goals in the cashew value chain.
- **Community Empowerment:** Shall prioritize equitable benefits, supporting rural farmers, women, and youth through fair practices and knowledge sharing.

1.8 Interpretation and Definitions: This Article shall prevent ambiguity and ensure

consistent understanding.

- **Association** shall mean the Cashew Quality Analysts' Association, Ghana (CQAAG).
- **Cashew Quality Analysis** shall mean the scientific and technical processes of inspecting, testing, grading, and certifying raw cashew nuts (RCN) and cashew kernels.
- **Quality Analyst** shall mean a professional engaged in cashew quality analysis.
- **Full Member** shall mean a member entitled to voting rights as defined in Article 2.
- **Associate Member** shall mean a non-voting member as defined in Article 2.
- **Board** shall mean the Board of Directors of the Association.
- **General Assembly** shall mean the supreme governing body of the C.Q.A.A.G.
- **AGM/ADM/EGM:** Annual General Meeting, Annual Delegates Meeting, Extraordinary General Meeting.
- **In Good Standing** shall mean a member who has paid all required dues and is not under suspension.
- **TCDA** shall mean the Tree Crops Development Authority (Act 1010).

1.9 Objectives:

1. Develop and advocate for National Quality Guidelines by 2027.
2. Achieve 100% adoption of standardized inspection protocols by 2027.
3. Create quality arbitration centers in production areas.
4. Implement moisture control projects at warehouses starting 2026.
5. Train and License 500 Cashew Controllers by 2028.

6. Organize annual conferences and digital resource platforms.
7. Promote ethical practices and Good Agricultural Practices (GAP).
8. Increase Local Value Addition and Certifications.
9. Conduct research and publish annual cashew quality reports.

Article Two (02): Membership

2.1 Eligibility: Open to individuals or entities (at least 16 years of age) agreeing to abide by the Constitution and Code of Conduct, and having no conflicting prior history.

2.2 Categories:

- **Full Members:** Experienced analysts with voting rights; eligible for TCDA licensing.
- **Associate Members:** Students or affiliates; non-voting; pay full registration and half dues.
- **Corporate Members:** Laboratories or processors; non-voting; pay full registration and half dues.
- **Honorary Members:** Distinguished individuals; non-voting; participate in advisory roles.

2.3 Application and Admission: Applications reviewed by the Membership Committee within 30 days. Membership becomes effective upon approval and payment of fees. Membership cards are produced at the National level.

2.4 Rights of Members: Attend meetings, vote (if eligible), receive publications, and access exclusive resources.

2.5 Duties of Members: Uphold Association principles, pay dues promptly, and comply with ethical standards.

2.6 Registration, Dues and Fees: Amounts determined by the Board and approved at the AGM. Associate and Corporate members pay half dues. Non-payment for 2+ years results in suspension.

2.7 Membership Card, Uniform and kits: Bio-data cards valid for 5 years. Uniforms and kits factored into fees.

2.8 Termination and Discipline:

- Termination via resignation or involuntarily for non-payment or ethical violations.
- Requires two-thirds vote of the Board after reports from the Ethical and Disciplinary Committee.
- Termination notice sent to TCDA within 30 days; license renewal prevented.

2.9 Reinstatement: Case-by-case review by Membership Committee requiring majority vote.

Article Three (03): General Assembly and Governance

3.1 The General Assembly: Supreme body for policy approval, Board elections, and accountability.

- **Procedures:** Includes AGM, ADM, EGM, and EDM.
- **Notice:** 21 days for general assemblies.

3.2 The National Level: Consists of National Executive Officers and the Board of

Directors.

- **National Executive Officers:** President, Vice-President, Secretary, Organizer, Treasurer, Assistant Treasurer. Term: 4 years.
- **The Board of Directors:** 9 to 15 members including Executives, Chapter representatives, and technical advisors. Oversight and strategic direction role.

3.3 National Committees:

- **Standing Committees:** Membership, Finance, Programs and Events, Nominating and Elections (NEC), Ethics and Disciplinary, Data Research and Management.
- **Ad-Hoc Committees:** Created for specific time-bound tasks.

3.4 The Chapter Level: Sampa, Drobo-Dormaa, Techiman-Bole, Tema-Port Chapters.

- **Structure:** Chapter Chair, Vice-Chair, Organizer, Secretary, Treasurer, Vice-Treasurer. Term: 3 years.
- **Reporting:** Monthly reports to National Executive Officers.
- **Finances:** Chapters retain 60% of dues for local use; 40% remitted to National. 100% of registration fees sent to National.

Article Four (04): Meetings

4.1 General Assemblies (AGM/ADM):

- **Quorum:** 20% of Full Members or 40% of Delegates.
- **Voting:** One member, one vote; simple majority for ordinary, two-thirds for special resolutions.

4.2 Board Meetings: Held at least four times a year. Quorum is a simple majority.

4.3 National Executives Meetings: Held at least once a month.

4.4 Chapter Meetings: Includes Annual Chapter General Meetings (ACGM) and monthly Executive meetings.

Article Five (05): Funding and Financial Provisions

5.1 Sources of Funds: Registration fees, annual dues, training proceeds, grants, and donations.

5.2 Safeguards: Board must approve all external funding to ensure independence.

5.3 Chapter Funds: Separate bank accounts; 40% remittance to National.

5.4 Welfare and Benevolence Fund: Established at Chapter levels for member assistance (bereavement, illness, etc.).

5.5 Financial Year: 1st January to 31st December. Audited annually by an external auditor.

Article Six (06): Transitional Provisions

6.1 Interim Appointments: Initial National President may appoint interim officers to operationalize the Association before the first AGM.

6.2 Term Specifics: National Secretary and Treasurer serve full 4-year terms from appointment. President serves 4 years non-extendable.

6.3 End of Transition: Period ends upon the first AGM.

Article Seven (07): Miscellaneous

7.1 Supremacy: The Constitution is the supreme governing document.

7.2 Common Seals: Kept by the National and Chapter Secretaries.

7.3 Indemnity: Officers indemnified against costs incurred in good faith during duty.

7.4 Commencement: Effective upon adoption by founding members.

PART 2: CODE OF ETHICS

Preamble

Members of the Cashew Quality Analysts' Association, Ghana (C.Q.A.A.G) proudly serve as Guardians of Ghana's Cashew Quality. This Code of Ethics establishes the highest standards of professional conduct, rooted in the Association's core values of Integrity, Excellence, Sustainability, Professionalism, Collaboration, and Community Empowerment.

All members—Full, Associate, Corporate, and Honorary—must uphold this Code in every aspect of their work, aligning with the Association's missions to enforce rigorous standards, build capacity, advocate for equitable practices, facilitate collaborations, and promote research and innovation.

This Code binds all members and supports enforcement through the Ethics and

Disciplinary Committee, as outlined in the Constitution.

Article 1: Integrity and Impartiality

1.1 Members shall perform cashew quality analysis (including inspection, testing, grading, and certification) with unwavering honesty, accuracy, and freedom from bias, influence, or corruption.

1.2 Members shall avoid conflicts of interest and decline assignments where personal, financial, or relational ties could compromise objectivity.

1.3 Members shall reject bribes, gifts, favors, or inducements that influence professional judgment.

1.4 Members shall report suspected ethical violations, fraud, or non-compliance with standards to the Ethics and Disciplinary Committee or relevant authorities (e.g., TCDA).

Article 2: Professional Excellence and Competence

2.1 Members shall maintain the highest levels of technical competence through ongoing education, training, and adherence to national and international standards (e.g., Ghana Standards Authority).

2.2 Members shall conduct analyses using approved methods (e.g., cut testing, moisture determination, KOR assessment, aflatoxin screening) with precision and reliability.

2.3 Members shall pursue continuous professional development and contribute to the

Association's capacity-building efforts, including licensing and examinations.

Article 3: Sustainability and Environmental Responsibility

3.1 Members shall promote and support environmentally responsible practices that ensure the long-term viability of cashew farming and ecosystems.

3.2 Members shall advocate for sustainable handling, reduced waste, and good agricultural practices (GAP) among stakeholders.

3.3 Members shall consider the environmental impact of quality control processes and recommend innovations that minimize harm.

Article 4: Fairness, Equity, and Community Empowerment

4.1 Members shall treat all stakeholders—farmers, traders, processors, women, youth, and rural communities—with respect, fairness, and without discrimination.

4.2 Members shall support equitable benefits in the cashew value chain, prioritizing fair returns for farmers and vulnerable groups.

4.3 Members shall foster knowledge sharing and empowerment through ethical practices and awareness campaigns.

Article 5: Collaboration and Professional Respect

5.1 Members shall collaborate constructively with fellow members, the Association, regulators (TCDA, CCG), security agencies, and international partners (e.g., African

Cashew Alliance).

5.2 Members shall respect the reputation of the profession and avoid actions that discredit the Association or cashew quality control.

5.3 Members shall maintain confidentiality of sensitive information obtained during professional duties, except where disclosure is required by law or Association rules.

Article 6: Compliance and Accountability

6.1 Members shall comply with this Code, the Association's Constitution, and all applicable laws of Ghana.

6.2 Violations of this Code may result in disciplinary actions, including warnings, suspension, or expulsion, as per Article 2 of the Constitution.

6.3 Members shall cooperate fully with investigations by the Ethics and Disciplinary Committee.

Adoption and Review

The Ethics and Disciplinary Committee shall recommend this Code to the General Assembly for adoption at an AGM or ADM. The Board shall review it periodically to ensure it remains relevant and effective.

MEMBERSHIP DECLARATION

By submitting this application and upon approval as a member of the Cashew Quality

Analysts' Association, Ghana (C.Q.A.A.G), I hereby declare and agree:

"I have read, understood, and fully accept the Constitution of the Cashew Quality Analysts' Association, Ghana (C.Q.A.A.G) and the Code of Ethics.

I commit to abide by all provisions, rules, and standards contained therein, to uphold the Association's core values of Integrity, Excellence, Sustainability, Professionalism, Collaboration, and Community Empowerment, and to faithfully discharge my duties as a member in advancing the objectives and missions of the Association.

I understand that any violation may result in disciplinary action, including suspension or termination of membership, in accordance with the Constitution."

This declaration shall be binding upon me for the duration of my membership.